



RIPOSTE LABORATORIES INC.

Daily Bread is baked quarterly in Kelowna,
BC. Free where you found it. Pay what you
can where you can't.



ISSN PENDING
№1 • SUMMER 2026

see you at the thaw ✕

PRINTED ON UNCEDED SYILX OKANAGAN TERRITORY IN A RUN OF 500. SET
IN IBM PLEX MONO AND UNIFRAKTURMAGUNTIA. ERRORS ARE OURS;
CORRECTIONS ARE YOURS; THE LEFTOVER INK WENT INTO THE STICKERS.
- PARRY. RIPOSTE.

FREE / PWYC

№1 • SUMMER 2026



Daily
Bread

Daily Bread

A QUEER MAGAZINE FOR THE OKANAGAN

You found the first issue of a queer magazine in a city that keeps telling us it doesn't have one. Kelowna has queer history, queer kids, queer elders, queer bakers and bureaucrats; what it hasn't had is paper that says so out loud.

ISSUE #1 • SUMMER 2026

KELOWNA'S COLLAPSE • 48 PP • PRINT RUN 500

BATCH #1 • FRESH

READ THE ISSUE ↓

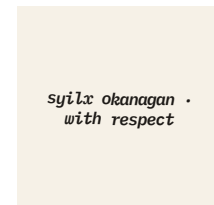
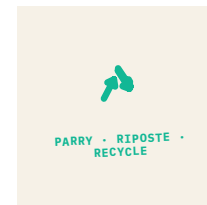
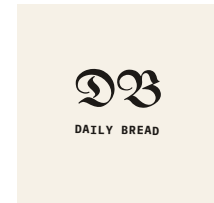
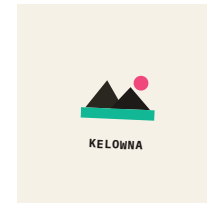
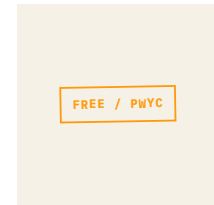
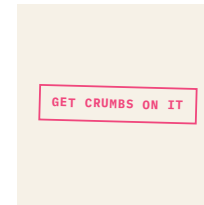
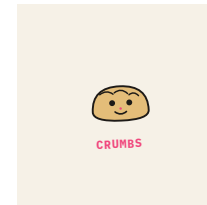


APPENDIX A3 • CUT ON A MACHINE



Stickers • crosshairs

Crosshairs 10 mm in from three corners of the trim: register the cutter on them, then cut with the cut file.



Cut from a copy printed at 100 % (Printer PDF, or Web PDF at actual size), not the booklet, which prints smaller. A Cricut uses the sticker page itself: the studio's Stickers for a cutter PNG, through Design Space.

Stickers · Brother ScanNCut

Brother ScanNCut: no marks needed. Put the page on the mat, Scan, Direct Cut: the outlines are the cut lines.



Cut from a copy printed at 100 % (Printer PDF, or Web PDF at actual size), not the booklet, which prints smaller. A Cricut uses the sticker page itself: the studio's Stickers for a cutter PNG, through Design Space.

OUR DAILY DREAD

S **I.** You found the first issue of a queer magazine in a city that keeps telling us it doesn't have one. Kelowna has queer history, queer kids, queer elders, queer bakers and bureaucrats; what it hasn't had is paper that says so out loud.

This issue is about collapse: the orchards, the venues, the rent math, the bridge traffic. Not because we're doomers, but because things fall apart here on schedule, and naming the schedule is the first act of repair.

Rip out the poster. Colour the cartoon. Mail us your fury and your recipes. This thing only works if you get crumbs on it.

— the editors X

EDITOR	your name here
ART + COMICS	open call
YOUNG VOICES DESK	three writers, 17-24
PRINTED ON	unceded syilx territory

Daily Bread is published on the unceded, ancestral territory of the syilx Okanagan people. We pay rent to a landlord and respect to a Nation, and we know only one of those is owed.



FUNDED BY RIPOSTE
LABORATORIES INC.

APPENDIX A1 • CUT ON A MACHINE

Stickers • Silhouette

Silhouette Studio: page 148 × 210 mm, Registration Marks on, Type 1, length 20 mm, thickness 0.5 mm, inset 10 mm. Open the cut file, then Send.



Cut from a copy printed at 100 % (Printer PDF, or Web PDF at actual size), not the booklet, which prints smaller. A Cricut uses the sticker page itself: the studio's Stickers for a cutter PNG, through Design Space.

CONTINUED FROM SHEET 41

FROM THE LAB

We share what we're building here, in the same pages, at the same volume as everyone else.

The deal, in writing: the Lab pays the printer and gets two pages. The editors answer to readers, not the funder. If that ever changes, the colouring page will let you know.

Sec.01 // contents · manifest / 48 pp

CONTENTS.

Twelve contributors made №1: writers aged 17-74, two photographers, one cartoonist, one very patient proofreader. Every byline is local. Every fee got paid before the printer did.

MANIFEST / 48 PP		DB-TOC
03	Our Daily Dread – editor's letter	HOUSE
06	Before the Bridge – a rude history	HISTORY
09	Vacancy – photo essay, Bernard Ave	PHOTO
12	Young Voices – three field reports	OPINION
19	Crumbs – ep.1, a golem seeks housing	COMIC
17	Forty Years of Nerve – Miss Demeanour	INTERVIEW
18	Lake Effect / Harvest – poems	LIT
21	The Wall – rip-out centrefold	ART
24	Colour Your Own Collapse	SATIRE
43	Peel Me – sticker sheet	STICKERS
15	The Waitlist – healthcare feature	ISSUES
25	The Lake Takes – fiction pt.1	LIT
41	From the Lab – funder disclosure	RIPOSTE
33	Ask a Local Gay / Reviews / Calendar	SERVICE
35	The Bite Back – restaurant critique	FOOD
37	Rotation – what we're listening to	MUSIC
29	The Rewind + Movies in the Park	FILM
30	Directory + Crumbs Mail	AID
44	Who Made This – staff, assembled	COLOPHON

Sec.02 // history · before the bridge

A RUDE HISTORY

The valley sold itself twice: first as Eden, then as equity. Fruit ranchers went broke so often the packinghouses printed their own scrip; when fruit died, the pitch became retirement sun; when the retirees priced out the pickers, the pitch became lakeside lofts. Each act ended the same way, with the people who did the work living further from the water.

The queer history is braided through all of it: dance halls with unofficial nights, friendship networks that doubled as housing lists, a scene that survived by being useful and quiet until it didn't have to be.

"quiet until it didn't have to be" — put on a shirt

LEDGER / WHAT COLLAPSED WHEN

ENTRY	STATUS
1913 fruit prices crater; scrip economy begins	BUST
1930s packinghouse layoffs, valley-wide	BUST
1958	

Sec.24

// peel me · sticker sheet · the leftover ink went here

PEEL ME.

The leftover ink went here. Print the page, cut along the dashes, and put the valley on your water bottle. Twelve stickers; no two collapses alike.

PRINT THIS SHEET □

OR PRESS CTRL / ⌘ + P · CUT ALONG THE DASHED LINES



RISO-PRINTED ON THE OFFCUTS. IF A COLOUR'S OFF, THAT'S THE POINT.

WIP

Esh – shop assistant, currently a whiteboard

DRAWING

Daily Bread №2 – theme vote

OPEN

First Friday open doors – bring clean
plastics

RECURRING

WHY FUND A MAGAZINE?

Because a lab that fixes material waste in a town
losing its cultural material would be doing half a
job. Paper is infrastructure. So are drag nights.
Line item approved.

TOUR THE SHOP: OPEN DOORS FIRST FRIDAYS · BRING
CLEAN #2 + #5 PLASTICS.

bridge opens; ferry workers obsolete overnight

PIVOT

1973 ALR freezes orchard speculation (briefly)

PARRY

1980s sawmill era ends; wine era begins

PIVOT

2003 firestorm; 239 homes, 30k evacuated

BURN

2017 flood year; the lake takes the boardwalk

FLOOD

2021 heat dome; hottest place in Canada, again

BURN

2024 last dedicated queer venue closes

BUST

2026 this magazine. your move, city.

RIPOSTE

METHOD – COMPILED FROM CITY ARCHIVES, NEWSPAPER
MORGUES, AND ELDERS WHO WERE THERE. CORRECTIONS
WELCOME AND EXPECTED.

ARCHIVAL PHOTO – 1958 FLOATING BRIDGE OPENING DAY

FIG. 1 — THE FLOATING BRIDGE, 1958. TRAFFIC ARRIVED; THE FERRY DIED THE SAME DAY.

Every boom since has made the same promise, and every bust has been treated as a surprise. Fruit prices collapsed. Sawmills closed. The 2003 firestorm ate 239 homes while the city watched from the beach.

This issue asks the impolite question: what if collapse isn't the exception here — what if it's the business model? The ledger has the receipts.

ARCHIVAL PHOTO — ORCHARD CREWS, 1910S

FIG. 2 — PICKING CREWS, RUTLAND BENCHES. THE APPLES WERE A PYRAMID SCHEME WITH ROOTS.

Sec. 16

// from the lab · funder disclosure, printed large



LABORATORIES INC.

FROM THE LAB

Full disclosure, printed large: this magazine is funded by Riposte Laboratories, a Kelowna outfit that counter-attacks waste with recycled-plastic injection molding and reclaimed-cell modular power.

CONTINUED ON SHEET 44 →

FUNDER DISCLOSURE · SIGNED

parry. riposte. recycle.

THIS QUARTER / STATUS BOARD

Q3 · 2026

REV. A

Plastic Works — molds v2, park benches from #5 tubs

LIVE

Project HEX — reclaimed-cell grading rig

☐ Water Rights & Wrongs

☐ Night Shift (who runs 2AM Kelowna)

MARK ONE · PHOTOGRAPH · SEND. DEMOCRACY.

Sec.02 // photo essay · Bernard Ave, 6am

VACANCY

Six storefronts, one morning, zero people. A walking tour of what the “best downtown in Canada” looks like before the patios open – and after the leases triple.

PHOTO — PAPERED-OVER STOREFRONT WINDOW

FIG. 3 — “FOR LEASE / GREAT EXPOSURE.” THE EXPOSURE IS DOING A LOT OF WORK.

PHOTO — EMPTY INTERIOR, CORDS ON FLOOR

PHOTO — SUN-BLEACHED MANNEQUIN

FIGS. 4-5 — SHOT ON EXPIRED FILM, APPROPRIATELY.

Sec.19

// submissions · №2 — "the thaw"

GET CRUMBS ON IT.

Serialized fiction, an open centrefold, a young-voices desk, a directory that stays current: №1 is a first draft of a scene arguing it exists. №2 is "The Thaw" — what comes back. Send us your fury and your recipes.

HELLO@DAILYBREAD.EXAMPLE

DEADLINE · SEPT 15

send poems. weird welcome.

WHAT WE TAKE

- **Art for the centrefold** — A4 landscape, 300dpi, any medium. We pay; rights stay yours.
- **Opinion (under 25)** — 500 words of correct anger.
- **Poems & fiction** — we read everything twice.
- **Comics** — pitch us six panels for the guest slot.
- **Listings & corrections** — free, always.

VOTE — №2 THEME

☐ The Thaw (what comes back)

Crumbs Mail

READER CORRESPONDENCE · №0 EDITION

This box is empty because you haven't written yet.
First issue problems. Fill it with fury, recipes,
corrections, crushes (anonymized), and photos of the
colouring page done wrong on purpose.

TIP JAR + SUBMISSIONS

SCAN, OR WRITE TO THE ADDRESS ON THE SUBMIT PAGE

PHOTO — FOURTH FRAME

PHOTO — LAST FRAME: HANDS TAPING A NEW POSTER UP

FIG. 6 — SOMEBODY ALWAYS TAPES SOMETHING UP. THAT'S THE WHOLE THESIS.

Vacancy isn't emptiness — it's a waiting room. Every
papered window downtown is a bet someone rich made
against someone broke. The essay ends where the bets get
called.

Sec. 03

// young voices desk · unreviewed. unedited. correct.

YOUNG VOICES

Three field reports from writers who can't vote yet but can already do the rent math. We paid them; we didn't touch a word.

REPORT 01

AGE 19 · HOUSING

NOBODY MY AGE CAN AFFORD TO STAY

I work two jobs and split a two-bedroom with three people, and I'm the success story. My group chat is a slow-motion goodbye party: Vernon, Calgary, mom's basement in Surrey.

"Every viewing is forty people deep and one of them is always crying."

Sec. 16

// listening · loud in the paste-up room

WHAT WE'RE LISTENING TO

Rotation

FULL PLAYLIST — UPDATED PER ISSUE

SEND US ONE SONG + ONE SENTENCE

STAFF ROTATION / #1

LOUD

"Bench Water" — local EP

THE CONNECTOR, AT NIGHT

ballroom sets — Paris Is Burning
warm-ups

PRE-SCREENING
HOMEWORK

snotty coast punk — 7" from a Rutland
garage

PASTE-UP
FUEL

a sylx songwriter's live tape

ASK AT THE RECORD STALL

disco edits for the beach assembly

AUG 15, BRING SPEAKERS

the diner jukebox, booth six

FIELD RECORDING, HONESTLY

whatever the night cook hums

UNRELEASED. PROTECTED.

we pay full price · we book under fake names · patios judged
by dog traffic · anywhere that feeds evacuation crews gets a
permanent star

Sec. 03

// young voices desk · unreviewed. unedited. correct.

REPORT 02

AGE 22 · COMING OUT

OUT AT THE PACKINGHOUSE

I came out at a bush party in Glenmore and the worst thing that happened was a guy named Tyler said "cool" and asked if I could drive him home. Not paradise, not hell, just a small city learning faster than its city council.

geography is the last closet

Sec. 03

// young voices desk · unreviewed. unedited. correct.

REPORT 03

AGE 17 · FIRE SEASON

I'VE EVACUATED TWICE AND I CAN'T VOTE YET

My childhood photos are sorted by smoke year. We packed the car in 2021 and again in 2023, and both times the adults on the radio called it unprecedented. It has precedent.

"I am the precedent."

Sec. 15 // food · no free meals, no mercy

The Bite Back

RESTAURANT CRITIQUE · NO FREE MEALS, NO MERCY

WINE BAR · LAKESHORE · \$\$\$\$

2/5 — GORGEOUS, HUNGRY

THE PLACE THAT REPLACED THE DINER

The room is stunning, the playlist is a moodboard, and the “heritage tomato moment” is one tomato. Our server was the best actor in the valley: she said “great choice” about a \$19 plate of air with total conviction. We left elegant and starving, then bought gas-station taquitos. Verdict: it photographs like a meal.

DINER · RUTLAND · \$

5/5 — PROTECT AT ALL COSTS

THE 24-HOUR SURVIVOR ON HWY 33

Coffee refills arrive before you ask, the hashbrowns have structural integrity, and the night cook remembers your order and your pronouns. Every collapse in this issue is survivable from booth six. Bring cash, tip like rent is due, because theirs is too.

HOUSE RULES

DRAG NIGHT · POP-UP

RIPS

"HARVEST MOON" AT THE COMMUNITY HALL

A gymnasium, a rented fog machine, and the best crowd this valley has produced. The floor is lava and the lava is love. Next one: see calendar.

BAKERY · DOWNTOWN

4/5

THE NEW SOURDOUGH PLACE ON ELLIS

The loaf is honest, the queue is chatty, and the owner slips day-olds to anyone who compliments the playlist. Crumb declined to comment, citing family.

CIVIC · ONGOING

0/5

COUNCIL PUBLIC-HEARING LIVESTREAM

Buffering as dramaturgy. Runtime: eternal. One star added for the councillor who said "housing is for people" out loud; four removed for the vote after.

WANT A REVIEW? WE COVER ANYTHING QUEER-ADJACENT AND OKANAGAN-MADE: SHOWS, MENUS, ZINES, HOT SAUCE, CITY COUNCIL MEETINGS (AS PERFORMANCE ART). THE ONLY CRITERION IS THAT WE CAN ATTEND, TASTE, OR ENDURE IT IN PERSON.

THE WAITLIST

Trying to find queer-competent healthcare in the Central Okanagan is a part-time job with no benefits. We phoned every clinic so you don't have to; everyone we reached described the same triangle of phone tag, referral limbo, and a highway.

14

MONTHS · AVG GENDER
CLINIC WAIT

2

PROVIDERS TAKING
NEW PATIENTS

400

KM TO THE NEAREST
ALTERNATIVE

"My GP is great. My GP is also in Vancouver, where I don't live."

"The pharmacist figured it out before any doctor did. Shout out Deb."

"I got my referral the same month my lease ended. Guess which one moved faster."

"Honestly? The group chat is the healthcare system."

FOUR OF ELEVEN INTERVIEWS · ALL ANONYMIZED · METHODOLOGY: SEE DIRECTORY

Ust a Local Gan

CERTIFIED · SINCE TUESDAY

My parents keep introducing me as their "roommate's friend." The roommate is my wife. Escalate or let it ride?

— TIRED IN LAKE COUNTRY

Send them a fridge magnet of your wedding photo every month. No note. Bureaucracy respects witnesses and parents respect fridges. By magnet six you'll be "the girls." By ten, they're paying for brunch.

Is it a red flag if a date says Kelowna has "no culture"?

— DEFENSIVE DOWNTOWN

It's a beige flag. Hand them this magazine, the calendar page, and a pen. If they come to one thing on the calendar, marry them. If they critique the font, you've met the editor — run.

Sec.18 // service · fire season – clip + fridge

Two evacuations in five years says keep it packed, not planned. Know your route out, your meeting spot, and one person out of town who takes the check-in calls. The writer in Young Voices shouldn't know this list better than city council does.

THE GO-BAG / FIRE SEASON CHECKLIST

- ☐ Water – 4L per person, rotate it
- ☐ Meds + a photographed prescription list
- ☐ Documents in a freezer bag (ID, insurance, lease – ha)
- ☐ Chargers, battery bank, cash in small bills
- ☐ N95s from the smoke drawer. You have a smoke drawer
- ☐ The pets. Count them twice. Then the neighbour's
- ☐ This magazine – morale is supplies

Sec.05 // interview · forty years of nerve

"We didn't have a bar, darling. We had basements, and we had nerve."

MISS DEMEANOUR · PERFORMING IN THE OKANAGAN SINCE 1986

"The audience got younger and the rent got meaner. In '86 the danger was people; now the danger is landlords. Where did everyone go when the venues closed? Nowhere, sweetheart; that's the secret. We're all still here, we just meet in gymnasiums and orchards and each other's kitchens. A scene isn't an address."

ARCHIVED · SHOEBOX FONDS

MD, continued: People ask if I'm bitter about the decades in basements. Bitter? Those basements had better sound systems than half the clubs I've played since. We recorded everything on cassette. Someone's nephew digitized it all last winter and I cried for a week. That's your history project right there – a drag queen's shoebox. The city archive called ME. I said darling, you're forty years late and you're paying for the shelving. They did. Progress is slow, then it's sudden, then it sends an invoice.

Late Effect

the ogopogo is real and she is tired
of being your tourism budget
she surfaces only for girls
who skip stones left-handed
and boys who came out in a parking lot
she keeps every ring ever thrown in.

— SUBMITTED FROM RUTLAND, AGE 20

Harvest

my grandmother thinned apples so the rest grow large
i learned it as economics
she meant it as mercy
this town keeps thinning people
and calling the fruit a miracle.

— SUBMITTED FROM EAST KELOWNA, AGE 24

☐ Telehealth counts. Bad wifi is still shorter than
400 km

☐ Bring a friend to appointments. Bureaucracy
respects witnesses

shout out Deb, seriously

Sec.18

// mutual aid · keep this page · verified quarterly

KEEP THIS PAGE / DIRECTORY

VERIFIED QUARTERLY · TEAR OUT OK

Crisis line (24/7, trans-competent)	placeholder – verify before print
Informed-consent clinic list	updated quarterly · this page
Youth drop-in (14-24) ◦	wed + sat · downtown
Mutual aid pantry	rutland · no questions
Legal aid – tenant defence	first mondays · library
Elder queer social (55+) ◦	thursdays · lakeshore
Sober hangs ◦	see calendar, marked ◦

A RESOURCE MISSING? WRONG NUMBER? TELL US – THIS PAGE IS THE WHOLE POINT.

WHAT ACTUALLY HELPS / CHECKLIST

FIELD-TESTED

- ☐ The informed-consent clinic list – updated quarterly
- ☐ Pharmacists can renew more than you think – ask directly

Sec.08 // crumbs · ep.1 · a golem seeks housing

CRUMBS

Our guest strip. Six panels, one loaf, zero vacancies. The slot is open, it pays, and the only brief is: make us laugh about the thing that isn't funny.

EP.1 · PENCILS, INK & CRUMBS BY OPEN CALL



TO BE CONTINUED IN №2 – "THE THAW." WANT THE GUEST SLOT? SIX PANELS TO HELLO@DAILYBREAD.EXAMPLE.

FULL-PAGE GUEST COMIC — A DIFFERENT LOCAL CARTOONIST EVERY
ISSUE. #1 GUEST: [NAME], "PARALLEL PARKING AS QUEER
PRAXIS"

The Rewind

CRITERION-SHELF DEEP CUTS

Old films, screened like they matter — because a town with no rep cinema deserves one anyway. Each issue: three from the queer canon, then we show them outside. Program notes below; lawn chairs on the calendar.

BRING — A BLANKET · BUG SPRAY · SOMEONE YOU'RE NERVOUS AROUND · A THERMOS (WE SELL NONE OF THESE ON PURPOSE)

#1 PROGRAM / NOTES

35MM ENERGY, DIGITAL BUDGET

Paris Is Burning (1990) — The ballroom documentary that gave the culture its vocabulary. Watch it with people; the applause is part of the text.

My Own Private Idaho (1991) — River Phoenix falls asleep on every road in the Northwest. The campfire scene alone is worth the mosquitoes.

The Watermelon Woman (1996) — Cheryl Dunye invents an archive because nobody kept one for her. Relevant to a magazine doing the same thing.

SUMMER SLATE / AT DUSK

RAIN MOVES US TO THE LAB

Aug 14 **Paris Is Burning (1990)**

City Park, at dusk

Sep 04 **My Own Private Idaho (1991)**

Ben Lee Park, at dusk

Sep 25 **The Watermelon Woman (1996)**

Rutland Centennial Park, at dusk

FREE / PWYC · CAPTIONS ON · PROJECTOR + POWER: RECLAIMED CELLS, PROJECT
HEX

VOTE — OCTOBER SCREENING

☐ Portrait of a Lady on Fire (2019)

☐ Hedwig and the Angry Inch (2001)

☐ Bound (1996)

MARK ONE · PHOTOGRAPH · SEND. FILM DEMOCRACY.

Sec.11

// the wall · rip-out centrefold · pull gently

THE WALL

The centrefold is a poster. Tear it out along the gutter and put it where a landlord can see it. This issue's wall belongs to the scene that refuses to be an address.

yes — actually rip it

CENTREFOLD #1 · RIP-OUT POSTER

ALSO ON THE WALLS / PLATE ROOM



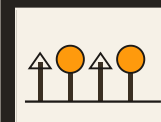
VACANCY

PHOTO ESSAY · BERNARD AVE



THE LAKE TAKES

INK ON FOUND PAPER



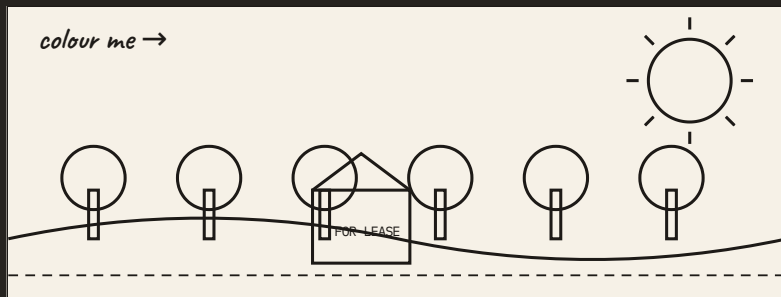
ORCHARD, AFTER

RISO · TWO COLOURS

COLOURING PAGE · PULL OUT

COLOUR YOUR OWN COLLAPSE

colour me →



The line-art page is yours. Crayon the orchard, redline the rent, sign the bottom. Photograph it and send it back; the best one runs the wall in №2.

Sec.14

// the calendar · aug-oct 2026 · clip + fridge

THE CALENDAR.

Listings are free; email by the 15th. Sober and all-ages options marked °.

AUG – OCT 2026

CLIP + FRIDGE

- Aug 07** **First Friday at the Lab** °
Riposte shop floor – tours, benches, zines

- Aug 14** **Movies in the Park №1** °
City Park – Paris Is Burning

- Aug 15** **Queer Beach Assembly** °
Gyro Beach, north end – bring shade to share

- Aug 22** **Harvest Moon drag night**
community hall – PWYC at the door

- Sep 05** **Zine-making + submission clinic** °
library makerspace – bring your fury

- Sep 15** **№2 submission deadline**
art, opinion, poems

- Sep 19** **Orchard walk with an elder** °
East Kelowna benches – history underfoot

- Oct 03** **Cassette night: the Shoebox Fonds**
venue TBA – Miss Demeanour presiding

- Oct 17** **Issue №2 launch + colouring contest**
location in №2. obviously

MOVIES IN THE PARK / HOSTED BY DAILY BREAD

"Okay," she told the water, the town, the whole arranged marriage of valley and debt. "Show me what you kept."

CONTINUED IN #2 - "THE THAW"

Serialized fiction runs across issues. Miss one and the lake keeps your bookmark.



Sec.08 // satire · crayon-proof paper

COLOUR YOUR OWN COLLAPSE

№1

LINE-ART SATIRE CARTOON, COMMISSIONED PER ISSUE. №1: CITY
COUNCIL, DRAWN AS CHEERFUL REALTORS, RIDE A SADDLED
OGOPOGO ACROSS THE LAKE WHILE TOWING THE LAST QUEER VENUE
ON A "LUXURY LOFTS" BARGE. PURE OUTLINES · NO FILLS ·
CRAYON-PROOF PAPER.

FIG. 8 — AISLIN-GRADE DISRESPECT, LOCAL EDITION

TEST YOUR CRAYONS: 

TAG US WITH YOUR FINISHED PAGE

Sec.11 // fiction · serialized

SHORT FICTION

THE LAKE TAKES

BY [AUTHOR] · ILLUSTRATION OPEN CALL

The realtor said the house had lake access, and it did, the way a mouth has throat access. June found the stairs behind the lilac on the second day — forty-one steps of split cedar going down to a dock that wasn't in the listing photos, because docks that old don't photograph, they testify.

Her grandmother had warned her about the lake in the language June only half-kept: it gives, but it keeps receipts. Every family on the bench had a story with the same shape — a ring, a brother, a hayfork, a name — something the water accepted and never gave back at the same size.

On the dock she found the offerings the winter had rearranged: a doll's shoe, a fishing licence from 1974, a phone in a sandwich bag, screen up, one notification still glowing like a lure. The lake was flat as a ledger. June, who had moved back for the cheap rent that no longer existed and the family that barely did, rolled her jeans and stepped down onto the first cold plank.